Iron Foundation

Introduction

Iron Foundation is a complete guide to building muscle as efficiently as possible. Whether you train one day per week or six, in a fully equipped gym or with only a pair of dumbbells, this program will help you maximize muscle growth while avoiding common mistakes.

My name is Owen, and lifting weights has completely changed my life. Like many people, I started as a skinny beginner with little understanding of how muscle growth actually worked. Over time, I learned the principles that consistently produce results: proper training, progressive overload, recovery, and nutrition. I created this guide to simplify those concepts and give you a clear roadmap to follow.

Many fitness programs make muscle building seem complicated. They overwhelm beginners with conflicting advice, endless exercise variations, and unrealistic expectations. Iron Foundation is designed to cut through the confusion and focus on what actually matters.

This program is built around a simple idea: train hard, recover properly, and gradually become stronger over time. If you consistently apply these principles, you can build a stronger, more muscular physique than you ever thought possible.

Before You Start

Before beginning the program, determine what equipment you have available.

Full Gym Access:

A gym with machines, cables, barbells, and dumbbells provides the greatest exercise variety and flexibility.

Limited Gym Access:

If you only have access to barbells, dumbbells, and cables, you can still build an incredible physique. Very little muscle growth is lost when proper exercise substitutions are made.

Dumbbells Only:

A pair of adjustable dumbbells is enough to build significant muscle. Every workout in this guide includes alternatives whenever possible.

No Equipment

A separate calisthenics version of Iron Foundation is currently under development.

Next, decide how many days per week you can realistically train. Consistency is more important than choosing the highest number.

- 1–2 Days: Minimal time commitment, slower progress.
- 3–4 Days: Excellent balance between recovery and muscle growth.
- 5–6 Days: Maximum training frequency and growth potential for dedicated lifters.

Avoid training seven days per week. Muscles grow during recovery, not while you are in the gym.

Choosing the Right Weight

For most exercises, select a weight that allows you to perform approximately 8–12 repetitions with proper form.

The final few repetitions should be challenging. Ideally, you should finish each set with 0–3 repetitions left before failure. On your final set, it is often acceptable to reach complete failure when it is safe to do so.

If an exercise becomes too easy, increase the weight, perform additional repetitions, or use a more difficult variation.

Progressive Overload

Progressive overload is the foundation of muscle growth.

Your body adapts to the demands you place on it. If those demands never increase, your progress will eventually stop.

For example, imagine you can perform 10 push-ups. After several weeks of training, those 10 repetitions may no longer challenge you. To continue building muscle, you must increase the difficulty by:

- Performing more repetitions
- Adding resistance
- Increasing training volume
- Slowing down the movement
- Using a more difficult variation

Every workout should be tracked. Record your exercises, sets, repetitions, and weights. Your goal is to gradually improve over time.

Small improvements may seem insignificant from workout to workout, but they compound into dramatic results over months and years.

Push Day

The push day focuses on the chest, shoulders, and triceps. Every exercise was selected to maximize muscle growth while minimizing unnecessary overlap.

Perform three working sets for each exercise.

1. Bench Press

5–8 repetitions

The bench press is your primary strength movement. Focus on controlled repetitions and progressive overload.

Alternatives:

- Dumbbell Bench Press

- Smith Machine Bench Press

2. Incline Press

8–12 repetitions

The incline press places greater emphasis on the upper chest while continuing to develop overall pressing strength.

Alternatives:

- Incline Dumbbell Press
- Smith Machine Incline Press

3. Shoulder Press

8–12 repetitions

The shoulder press develops the front and side deltoids while improving overall pressing strength.

Alternatives:

- Dumbbell Shoulder Press
- Machine Shoulder Press

4. Chest Press

8–12 repetitions

The chest press allows you to safely push close to failure while accumulating additional chest volume.

Alternatives:

- Dumbbell Bench Press
- Push-Ups

5. Lateral Raise

12–20 repetitions

Lateral raises are one of the most effective exercises for building wider shoulders and improving overall proportions.

Alternatives:

- Dumbbell Lateral Raise
- Cable Lateral Raise

6. Pec Deck or Chest Fly

10–15 repetitions

This movement isolates the chest and provides a strong contraction.

Alternatives:

- Dumbbell Fly
- Cable Fly

7. Dips

8–12 repetitions

Dips are excellent for chest and triceps development.

Alternatives:

- Assisted Dips
- Close-Grip Push-Ups

8. Skull Crushers

10–15 repetitions

Finish the workout by targeting the triceps directly.

Alternatives:

- Dumbbell Skull Crushers
- Overhead Triceps Extensions

Pull Day

The pull day focuses on building the back, biceps, rear delts, traps, and forearms. The goal is to develop a wide, thick, and balanced upper body while improving posture and pulling strength.

Every exercise should be performed for **3 working sets** unless otherwise stated. Most sets should finish with **0–3 reps in reserve (RIR)**, meaning you are close to failure but still maintaining good form.

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1. Pull-Ups or Lat Pulldown

6–10 repetitions

This is your primary vertical pulling movement and the foundation of back width. It develops the lat muscles, which create the V-taper shape.

Focus on driving your elbows down toward your hips rather than pulling with your arms.

Alternatives:

- Assisted pull-ups
- Neutral-grip pulldown
- Single-arm lat pulldown

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2. Chest-Supported Row

8–12 repetitions

This is your main horizontal pulling movement for back thickness. It targets the mid-back, rhomboids, and lats without stressing the lower back.

Keep your chest supported and control both the stretch and contraction.

Alternatives:

- Machine row
- Seated cable row
- Dumbbell chest-supported row

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3. Straight-Arm Pulldown

10–15 repetitions

This isolates the lats and reinforces proper lat activation. It is one of the best movements for improving the mind-muscle connection with your back.

Alternatives:

- Dumbbell pullover

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4. Face Pull

12–20 repetitions

Face pulls target the rear delts and upper back while improving shoulder health and posture. This is essential for balanced shoulder development.

Alternatives:

- Rear delt dumbbell fly
- Reverse pec deck

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5. Dumbbell Shrug

10–15 repetitions

Shrugs build the upper trapezius muscles, adding thickness to the upper back and neck area.

Squeeze at the top and control the lowering phase.

Alternatives:

- Barbell shrug
- Machine shrug

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6. Incline Dumbbell Curl

8–12 repetitions

This exercise places the biceps under a deep stretch, making it highly effective for overall arm development.

Alternatives:

- Standing dumbbell curl
- Cable curl

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7. Preacher Curl

8–12 repetitions

This curl variation emphasizes the shortened position of the biceps, improving peak contraction and control.

Alternatives:

- Dumbbell preacher curl
- Concentration curl

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8. Hammer Curl

10–15 repetitions

Hammer curls target the brachialis and forearms, which increases overall arm thickness and grip strength.

Alternatives:

- Rope hammer curl
- Cross-body dumbbell hammer curl

Pull Day Summary

This pull day is built around three core principles:

- **Width (lat development)** through vertical pulling
- **Thickness (mid-back development)** through rowing movements
- **Detail and symmetry** through rear delt and arm isolation work

Progressive overload is essential. When you reach the top of a rep range with good form, increase the weight slightly and repeat the process.

Leg Day

Leg day focuses on building the quadriceps, hamstrings, glutes, and calves. Strong legs are essential for overall strength, athletic performance, and a balanced physique. This workout is designed to build size, strength, and symmetry in the lower body while minimizing unnecessary complexity.

Every exercise should be performed for **3 working sets**. Most sets should finish with **0–3 reps in reserve (RIR)**, staying close to failure while maintaining proper form.

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1. Squat

5–8 repetitions

The squat is the foundation of lower body development. It builds overall leg mass by targeting the quads, glutes, and core.

Focus on depth, control, and consistent technique throughout every rep.

Alternatives:

- Hack squat
- Smith machine squat
- Goblet squat

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2. Romanian Deadlift

8–12 repetitions

The Romanian deadlift targets the hamstrings and glutes through a controlled hip hinge pattern. It is one of the most effective exercises for posterior chain development.

Keep a slight knee bend and emphasize a strong hamstring stretch.

Alternatives:

- Dumbbell Romanian deadlift
- Cable pull-through

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3. Leg Press

10–15 repetitions

The leg press allows for heavy quad-focused training without requiring full-body stability. It is ideal for accumulating volume safely.

Alternatives:

- Bulgarian split squat
- Dumbbell split squat

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4. Leg Curl

10–15 repetitions

This exercise isolates the hamstrings and complements hip hinge movements by training knee flexion.

Control both the lowering and contraction phases.

Alternatives:

- Seated leg curl machine
- Stability ball curl
- Dumbbell leg curl variation

5. Leg Extension

10–15 repetitions

Leg extensions isolate the quadriceps and help fully develop the front of the legs. This is an important movement for shaping and definition.

Alternatives:

- Sissy squat
- Slow tempo bodyweight squat

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6. Bulgarian Split Squat

8–12 repetitions

This unilateral exercise builds strength, balance, and symmetry between both legs while heavily targeting the quads and glutes.

Alternatives:

- Walking lunges
- Step-ups

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7. Standing Calf Raise

12–20 repetitions

Calves respond best to high-repetition, high-control training. Focus on a full stretch at the bottom and a strong squeeze at the top.

Alternatives:

- Seated calf raise
- Dumbbell calf raise

Leg Day Summary

This leg day builds complete lower body development through a combination of compound lifts, unilateral work, and isolation exercises. It balances strength and hypertrophy while ensuring no major muscle group is neglected.

Progressive overload is essential. Once you reach the top of a rep range with proper form, increase the weight slightly and repeat the process.

P/P/L/R is the perfect split for muscle growth, and it is what I use. However, it does not work on a weekly basis which has created problems for me, so if you hit six days a week that is completely fine. For those of you who can not make six days, options remain. For four days hit an upper lower split that looks like this:

4-Day Split (Upper / Lower)

This is one of the most effective “minimal time but still serious gains” splits.

Day 1 – Upper

- Bench Press
- Row
- Incline Press
- Lat Pulldown

- Lateral Raise
- Curl
- Triceps

Day 2 – Lower

- Squat
- Romanian Deadlift
- Leg Press
- Leg Curl
- Calves

For three days or less hit full body:

1. Squat or Leg Press

5–10 repetitions

This is your main lower body compound movement. It builds overall leg mass and strength.

Focus on controlled depth and steady progression over time.

Alternatives:

- Hack squat
- Goblet squat
- Dumbbell squat

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2. Bench Press or Dumbbell Press

5–8 repetitions

This is your primary upper body push movement. It builds chest, shoulders, and triceps strength.

Alternatives:

- Incline dumbbell press
- Machine chest press
- Push-ups (weighted if possible)

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3. Pull-Ups or Lat Pulldown

6–10 repetitions

This is your main back width exercise. It develops the lats and creates the V-taper look.

Alternatives:

- Assisted pull-ups
- Single-arm pulldown
- Dumbbell row (lat focus)

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4. Romanian Deadlift

8–12 repetitions

This movement targets the hamstrings and glutes while strengthening the posterior chain.

Focus on a slow stretch and controlled hip hinge.

Alternatives:

- Dumbbell Romanian deadlift
- Cable pull-through

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5. Seated Row or Chest-Supported Row

8–12 repetitions

This builds mid-back thickness and balances pressing movements.

Alternatives:

- Machine row
- Dumbbell chest-supported row

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6. Shoulder Press

8–12 repetitions

This develops overall shoulder mass and pressing strength.

Alternatives:

- Dumbbell shoulder press
- Machine shoulder press

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7. Lateral Raise

12–20 repetitions

This isolates the side delts, which are key for wider-looking shoulders and a better V-taper.

Alternatives:

- Cable lateral raise
- Dumbbell lateral raise

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8. Curl Variation

8–12 repetitions

This targets the biceps and improves arm size and shape.

Alternatives:

- Incline dumbbell curl
- Cable curl
- Barbell curl

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9. Triceps Extension or Pushdown

10–15 repetitions

This isolates the triceps and completes upper arm development.

Alternatives:

- Overhead dumbbell extension
- Skull crushers
- Rope pushdown

Full Body Summary

This workout is designed to stimulate every major muscle group efficiently in a single session. It combines compound lifts for strength with isolation movements for muscle growth and symmetry.

Progressive overload is essential. When you reach the top of a rep range with good form, increase the weight slightly and repeat the process.

Full body training works best when performed 2–3 times per week with at least one rest day between sessions.

Core Training

The core is responsible for stability, posture, force transfer, and injury prevention. A strong core improves performance in every lift, especially squats, deadlifts, presses, and rows.

Unlike most muscle groups, the core can be trained more frequently because it recovers quickly and is constantly active in daily life.

For best results, core training should be performed **3–6 times per week**, and in many cases can be included **briefly after every workout**. This does not mean exhausting the abs daily, but instead training them consistently with controlled volume.

The goal is strength, control, and endurance—not just visible abs.

How to Train the Core

Core training should include three main functions:

- **Flexion (crunching movement)**
- **Stability (resisting movement)**
- **Hip flexion (leg raise movements)**

A complete core program includes all three.

Perform **2–3 sets per exercise**. These can be added at the end of workouts or done on separate light days.

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1. Hanging Leg Raise

10–15 repetitions

This movement targets the lower abs and hip flexors while improving overall core control. Focus on slow, controlled lifting without swinging.

Alternatives:

- Captain’s chair leg raise
- Lying leg raise
- Reverse crunch

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2. Cable Crunch

10–15 repetitions

This is one of the best exercises for direct abdominal hypertrophy. It trains spinal flexion under resistance, which is essential for building thicker abs.

Alternatives:

- Machine crunch
- Weighted crunch
- Dumbbell crunch

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3. Plank

30–60 seconds

The plank builds deep core stability by resisting spinal movement. It strengthens the transverse abdominis, which supports all major lifts.

Alternatives:

- RKC plank
- Weighted plank

- Dead bug hold

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4. Ab Wheel Rollout

8–12 repetitions

This is an advanced core movement that builds serious strength and control through anti-extension (resisting lower back collapse).

Alternatives:

- Barbell rollout
- Stability ball rollout
- Body saw plank

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5. Russian Twist

12–20 repetitions per side

This trains rotational control and oblique development. Use slow, controlled movement rather than speed.

Alternatives:

- Cable woodchop
- Medicine ball twist
- Dumbbell twist

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6. Side Plank

30–45 seconds per side

This strengthens the obliques and improves spinal stability and posture.

Alternatives:

- Weighted side plank
- Cable side bend hold

How Often to Train Core

Core training can be structured in three ways depending on recovery and training style:

Option 1: After Every Workout (Recommended)

- 1–2 core exercises after each session
- Keeps volume spread out
- Best for consistency and recovery

Option 2: 3–4 Times Per Week

- Dedicated core finishers
- Slightly higher volume per session

Option 3: 2 Times Per Week

- Higher effort sessions
- More fatigue per workout

Core Training Summary

The core should not be trained like a traditional muscle group that only gets hit once per week. Instead, it should be trained consistently with moderate volume and high control.

A strong core improves:

- Lifting strength
- Posture and stability
- Injury prevention
- Athletic performance
- Aesthetic physique development

Progress comes from gradually increasing resistance, time under tension, and control—not just doing more repetitions.

Rest Time Between Sets

Rest time is a key factor in performance and muscle growth. The goal is to balance recovery so you can perform high-quality sets while still creating enough fatigue for adaptation.

Compound Movements

These include: squat, bench press, rows, pull-ups, shoulder press.

Rest: 2–3 minutes

These exercises require more energy and nervous system recovery. Longer rest allows you to lift heavier weights and maintain proper form.

Isolation Movements

These include: curls, triceps extensions, lateral raises, leg extensions, leg curls.

Rest: 60–90 seconds

Shorter rest keeps tension on the muscle and increases training intensity without needing heavy loads.

Core and Calves

Rest: 30–60 seconds

These muscles recover quickly and respond well to higher density training.

Warm-Up Protocol

A proper warm-up improves performance, reduces injury risk, and prepares both the muscles and nervous system for heavy training.

Step 1: General Warm-Up (5–10 minutes)

Light cardio such as:

- Treadmill walking
- Stationary bike
- Rowing machine

This increases blood flow and body temperature.

Step 2: Dynamic Movement Prep (3–5 minutes)

Controlled movements that prepare joints and muscles:

- Arm circles
- Band pull-aparts
- Bodyweight squats
- Hip hinges
- Shoulder rotations

Avoid static stretching before lifting heavy weights.

Step 3: Specific Warm-Up Sets

Before your first main compound lift, perform 2–4 warm-up sets:

Example (Bench Press):

- Empty bar × 10 reps
- 50% working weight × 6 reps
- 70% working weight × 3–5 reps
- Then begin working sets

This gradually prepares your body for heavy loading.

Week-by-Week Progression

Progression is the most important part of muscle growth. Without it, your body has no reason to adapt.

Double Progression Method

Each exercise has a rep range (example: 8–12 reps).

Step 1

Start with a weight you can control within the lower end of the range.

Step 2

Each week, try to:

- Add 1–2 reps per set OR
- Add a small amount of weight

Step 3

Once you reach the **top of the rep range for all sets**, increase weight and restart at the lower end.

Example (Dumbbell Curl 8–12 reps)

- Week 1: 25 lb × 10, 9, 8
- Week 2: 25 lb × 11, 10, 9
- Week 3: 25 lb × 12, 12, 11
- Week 4: 30 lb × 9, 8, 8

Key Rule

Progress is not linear every workout. Focus on long-term improvement across weeks, not daily perfection.

Weekly Progress Tracking Template

Tracking your progress is essential for ensuring consistent improvement. If you are not tracking, you are guessing.

Use this template weekly.

Week: _______

Body Metrics

- Body weight: ________
- Estimated sleep average: _______ hours
- Energy levels (1–10): ________

Strength Progress

Main Lifts

- Bench Press: _______ lbs × _______ reps
- Squat: _______ lbs × _______ reps
- Pull-Ups / Lat Pulldown: _______ lbs × _______ reps
- Row Variation: _______ lbs × _______ reps
- Shoulder Press: _______ lbs × _______ reps

Accessory Progress

- Lateral Raise: _______
- Curl Variation: _______
- Triceps Exercise: _______
- Leg Extension / Curl: _______

Notes

- What improved this week?

- What felt difficult?

- What will I focus on next week?

Goal for Next Week

Tracking Rules

- If strength is going up → you are progressing
- If weight is stable and strength is going up → recomposition is happening
- If nothing is improving for 2–3 weeks → adjust food, sleep, or training intensity

To improve more, check out a forged diet for nutrition, advance for muscle growth and fat loss, warrior conditioning for fat loss without losing your gains, and forged sleep for perfect recovery.

Books That Support Iron Foundation

Strength & Hypertrophy Foundations

- Strength Training Anatomy
    - Visual breakdown of muscle activation in compound and isolation lifts

    - Supports exercise selection logic (push/pull/legs structure)
- Science and Development of Muscle Hypertrophy
    - One of the most important hypertrophy textbooks
    - Direct support for:
        - 8–15 rep hypertrophy range
        - progressive overload
        - volume-based growth
        - proximity to failure (RIR concept)
- Essentials of Strength Training and Conditioning
    - “Gold standard” certification textbook (used for CSCS certification)
    - Supports:
        - rest times
        - periodization
        - strength vs hypertrophy differences
        - training structure (split programming)
- Practical Programming for Strength Training
    - Explains progressive overload and adaptation cycles
    - Supports linear progression + long-term overload principles

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Programming / Training Structure

- The Renaissance Diet 2.0
    - Not diet-focused here, but training sections are highly relevant
    - Introduces:
        - MEV / MAV / MRV (minimum and maximum recoverable volume concepts)
        - fatigue management
        - deload reasoning
- Scientific Principles of Strength Training
    - Direct framework for:
        - weekly set targets
        - progression systems

        - fatigue vs stimulus balance

Key Scientific Research Supporting Iron Foundation

1. Progressive Overload

- Key idea: muscle grows only when mechanical tension increases over time
- Supported by:
    - Schoenfeld (2010, 2016 reviews on hypertrophy mechanisms)

Takeaway:
Your entire progression system (reps → load increases) is scientifically correct.

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2. Hypertrophy Rep Ranges (5–30 reps work, but sweet spot exists)

- Schoenfeld et al. (2017 meta-analysis)
- Morton et al. (2016)

Key finding:

- Muscle growth is similar across a wide rep range
- BUT moderate loads (6–15 reps) are most efficient for:
    - mechanical tension
    - fatigue balance
    - adherence

✔ This directly supports your:

- 5–8 compound work
- 8–12 hypertrophy work
- 12–20 isolation work

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3. Training to Failure (RIR system)

- Grgic et al. (2021 review)
- Sampson & Groeller (2016)

Findings:

- Failure is NOT required for growth
- Close-to-failure (0–3 RIR) produces similar hypertrophy
- Failure increases fatigue disproportionately on compounds

✔ This supports your:

- “compounds = stop 1–3 RIR”
- “isolations = optional failure”

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4. Training Volume = Primary Driver of Growth

- Schoenfeld et al. (2017 dose-response meta-analysis)

Findings:

- More weekly sets = more hypertrophy (up to a recovery limit)

✔ This supports your:

- weekly set targets per muscle group
- push/pull/legs volume structure

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5. Frequency (how often you train muscles)

- Schoenfeld et al. (2016 meta-analysis)

Findings:

- Frequency matters less than total weekly volume
- Training a muscle 2x/week is slightly superior for distribution of volume

✔ This supports:

- PPL (2x/week exposure)
- Upper/lower splits
- Full body 2–3x/week

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6. Rest Times Between Sets

- de Salles et al. (2009)
- Schoenfeld (2016 review)

Findings:

- Longer rest (2–3 min) improves strength and volume on compounds
- Short rest still effective for isolation work

✔ This supports your:

- compound vs isolation rest separation

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7. Core Training Principles

- McGill, S. (Spine biomechanics research)

Findings:

- Core training should emphasize:
    - stability
    - anti-extension
    - anti-rotation

✔ This supports:

- planks
- ab wheel
- controlled core progression
